

before you buy:

How much will each use cost? We don't love rules, but we like the \$1 use rule as a guideline. So, if something costs \$20, will you use it at least twenty times (\$1 per use?). If not, is it truly worth the cost? This can help you make your budget too. If you want to keep your clothes budget to \$1 per wear, then theoretically you wouldn't need to spend more than \$365 per year on clothes!

How long do I have to work for it? How many hours are you going to have to work to earn it? If you make \$25 an hour, is a \$100 pair of shoes worth half a day of work? This is an eye-opening question that you could ask with any transaction. Calculate how many hours you have to work to pay for your living and transportation expenses, then see if that \$100 pair of shoes is worth four hours!

Is it filling a need? We often already have something at home that can serve the same purpose. Think first if you have something at home that can fill the need, even if it's not perfect, before you fill your home with more stuff.

It may be awkward and inconvenient to place these physical and time barriers to your shopping, but it's worth it, especially if comparison and perfectionism are stealing your joy (and money).

The Hunt

Finding a deal is the modern-day equivalent of hunting your own dinner. RetailMeNot found⁴ that two-thirds of consumers have made a purchase they weren't originally planning to make solely based on finding a coupon or discount, and 80 percent said they feel encouraged to make a first-time purchase with a brand that is new to them if they are offered a discount. Almost half said they would avoid brands that do not provide offers. Which sounds silly until you realize it's 100 percent true.

In 2012, Ron Johnson, the former head of Apple's retail stores, became the new JCPenney CEO. He immediately unveiled a sweeping overhaul to their marketing strategy: no coupons and discounts. Instead, he replaced them with "everyday low prices." No more gimmicks, just "fair and square" pricing.

Customers hated it.⁵